The historic Sunder Nursery in Delhi is set to be the venue for the inaugural theatre festival by the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art (KNMA) from October 14-20. Reinforcing its commitment to multidisciplinary artistic expression, KNMA has attempted to curate a thoughtful festival with time and space for acts of creation and deliberation, says curator Kirtana Kumar. "Besides the 12 productions, we also have a workshop on transcultural practice, a lecture demonstration on the people's art movement in Sri Lanka and a symposium with a lovely cohort of theatre-makers and academics who have something valuable to share about contemporary theatre," she adds. "We have a focused theme—The Power of Vulnerability—because it's exciting to reframe vulnerability as a marvellous idea of the zeitgeist, of the sure knowledge of our shared human vulnerability."

The festival will open with Beesu Kamsale, an acrobatic folk form associated with men of the Halu Kuruba community of the Malé Mahadeshwara hills, near Chamrajnagar and Mandya, Mysore.

Besides, the KNMA Theatre Festival will host various performances to create platforms for voices, ideas and forms to flow, particularly for those not always visible in the nation's gaze. While it's difficult to pick one over the other, Kumar has some recommendations. "*Portal Waiting* is an unmissable aural theatre-cum-rock concert experience. *Project Darling* is a thrilling, radical and hilarious piece of intermedial ensemble theatre, while *Talki* is performed by transwomen over the age of 55. It is the first time we will be seeing something like this on the national stage."

There's also *Love and Information*, comprising over 50 scenes in seven sections. The adaption of Caryl Churchill's play follows a non-linear narrative and has no central characters. Also on the roster is *Be Loved*, a political cabaret, queer performance and song-dance gala all at once.

It doesn't end there, says Kumar. Adapted from the Aranyakanda of the Ramayana, *Vali Vadha* tells the story of the two *vanaras*, or forest-dwelling brothers, Vali and Sugreeva. In this episode, Vali and Sugreeva are estranged and must confront the *rakshasas*, Mayavi and Dundubhi, to protect the kingdom of Kishkindha. "*Vali Vadha* is a Yakshagana performance and audiences will be able to witness the entire ritual, right from the makeup and costuming, through to the finale," she adds.

The KNMA Theatre Festival is being held at Sunder Nursery in Delhi from Oct. 14-20

The *Enchanted Walk*, presented by the Katkatha Puppet Arts Trust, will be a giant puppet parade and a fitting finish to the festival. "How we take our primacy for granted! Yet, plants and insects have been around far longer than Homo sapiens. In this finale, we are invited to co-mingle with insects and arthropods. To appreciate our interconnectedness. Enter a labyrinth with a host of dragonflies, and visit a ladybird's dressing room...," concludes Kumar. ■

–Geetika Sachdev

FESTIVAL HIGHLIGHTS AND EVENTS

The festival opens on Oct. 15 with Uttarakhand's Cholia folk dance and a violin performance by Dr N. Rajam and her granddaughter Ragini Shankar. It will conclude with a performance *by Usha Uthup* on Oct. 29. *Other key performances include:*

- *Oct. 16:* Kathak by **Rajendra Gangani** at 8 pm
- *Oct. 17:* Sitar by **Avaneendra Sheolikar** at 7pm, followed by **Malini Awasthi** at 8 pm
- *Oct. 19:* Classical vocalists **Sajan Misra and Swaransh Misra** at 8 pm
- *Oct. 22:* **Santoor-Sitar jugalbandi** at 7 pm, followed by ghazals by **Pratibha Singh Baghel** at 8pm
- *Oct. 25:* Kathak by **Shinjini Kulkarni** at 7 pm, followed by the **Wadalis** at 8 pm

includes more than 30 celebrated artists, with performances by Sufi singers like the Wadalis, folk artistes such as Malini Awasthi and Osman Mir, and classical vocalists like Sajan Mishra and his son Swaransh. Instrumental virtuosos, including violinist Vidushi Kala Ramnath and flautist Pravin Godkhindi, will also grace the stage.

A crucial part of Virasat is its support for over 350 artisans and 300 artists. "The famous crafts bazaar of Virasat brings them thousands of customers...this marketing support has financially empowered the artisans," says Singh. He also highlights Virasat's impact on preserving folk traditions: "We revived Chakravyuh, the environmental theatre of Kedar Valley, and have created a folk orchestra in the mountains, providing employment to many tradition-bearers".

With its diverse line-up of performances, Virasat 2024 promises to be a dynamic celebration of our artistic heritage. ■

–Nikhil Sardana